

YOU'VE ALREADY STARTED. THAT'S NOT THE PROBLEM.

Quiet traction is one of the most stressful places to be as a founder — you're not stalled enough to obviously quit, and not confirmed enough to confidently keep going. That's exactly what customer conversations are for: not to start over, but to find out what to keep, what to change, and what to stop. Nothing you've built is wasted. It's data — you just haven't asked it the right questions yet.

VENTURE SIGNAL Gaining Real Momentum	BUILD STATUS Mockup / landing page
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YOUR SINGLE HIGHEST-LEVERAGE MOVE

Turn your **strongest interview insight** into one specific, testable value proposition.

WHAT YOU TOLD US

Customer conversations so far	A solid sample — 5 to 14
Can you name the exact buyer?	I have a rough picture
What they do about it today	I've seen or heard it firsthand
Real commitment shown	Strong verbal interest
How much is built	Mockups, sketches, or a landing page
Business entity	Yes — an LLC

WHY THIS IS THE MOVE

This is the stage where people start taking you seriously — but not yet seriously enough to write a check, sign a contract, or bet their own credibility on yours. The move from here isn't to throw out what you've made — it's testing it against real customers before spending more time or money assuming you already know the answer.

As a technical founder, this usually isn't a build problem — it's a proof problem. The instinct is to keep shipping; the credibility investors and customers actually check for is whether anyone asked for it first.

You already have signal. The work now is turning the strongest thing you heard into one claim sharp enough to be wrong — and then testing that claim instead of adding features.

WRITE THE CLAIM IN THEIR WORDS, NOT MARKETING LANGUAGE

The specific role who buys this

Their situation, in the words you actually heard

The progress they’re trying to make

What their current workaround costs them

FIND THE DEAL-KILLER

- 1. List the three things that must be true for this to work.
- 2. For each, ask: if this is false, does the venture *end* — or just get harder? Usually only one of them ends it.
- 3. That's the one you test next. Not the easiest one, and not the one you’re most confident about.

ASSUMPTION	IF FALSE, DOES IT END THIS?	HOW CONFIDENT AM I, HONESTLY?

DESIGN ONE TEST

The assumption I’m testing

What I will actually do (not build)

How many people, and by when

Pass looks like

Fail looks like

What I’ll do if it fails

A test you cannot fail is not a test. If you can’t write the fail line, you’re planning a demo rather than an experiment.

These are the signals investors, partners, and serious customers tend to check — at any stage, in any industry. None of them are OM's invention, and none of them require anyone's permission to start working on. Here's where your own answers put you today.

SIGNAL	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE	WHERE YOU ARE TODAY
Customer evidence	Conversations with real potential buyers about what they actually did — not what they say they might do.	IN PLACE
A named buyer	A specific role you can describe, including how their day works — not a demographic or a market segment.	PARTLY
The current workaround	What people do about this today, seen or heard firsthand. It's what you're really competing against.	IN PLACE
Real commitment	Money, a signature, access, or scheduled time. Verbal interest is common; committed action is rare and it's what gets remembered.	PARTLY
Build maturity <i>tracked separately</i>	How much exists today. Deliberately kept apart from the signals above — a working product doesn't substitute for proof someone wants it, and having nothing built doesn't count against you.	MOCKUP / LANDING PAGE

ONE WE DIDN'T ASK — BUT YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO ANSWER

What would make you walk away from this idea? Being able to name the evidence that would change your mind is, on its own, a strong signal to anyone evaluating you: it shows you're testing a belief rather than defending one. Worth writing down before your next conversation.

IF IT'D HELP TO TALK IT THROUGH

If you'd rather not do this part alone, **Session 3 — 4 · Phase 01 — 02: UVP + MVP, Evidence to Strategy** of Builder 1.0 is built around this exact move. But nothing on the previous page requires a program, or us — start there either way.

Book a 20-minute conversation: opportunitymachine.org
Call: (337) 769-4085 · **Email:** info@opportunitymachine.org
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